

Student Writing Sample B

I am a forensic anthropologist. As a forensic anthropologist, it is my job to identify the skeletal remains of unknown people in order to figure out who they are and why they died. Last week when I was walking my dog, he found a bone and the bone was human. It was my job to identify the body.

The first thing I did was get someone to pick up the decedent's bones and bring them to my office to examine. Then, I went to work to determine the victim's biological profile. In the article "What is Forensic Anthropology?" the author writes that the biological profile is the age, sex, height, and race of the person. Determining the biological profile is an important early step in identifying human remains. I figured out the age of the victim by checking the decedent's sutures of the skull, the teeth, the collarbone, the ends of the long bones in the arms and legs, the pubic symphysis, which is the area where the hipbones meet, and the joints between bones where the bones and cartilage meet. Angela Libal explains in the chapter "Identifying the Victim" that checking those bones and teeth help figure out someone's age because they all wear with age. After the age, I determined the sex of the decedent by checking the pelvis. The pelvis was wide so I knew it was a woman. After that, I found out the race by checking the shape of the skull, teeth and body's joints. Libal explains in "Identifying the Victim" that the skull, teeth and joints are different in the different races. Next, I found out the height of the decedent by measuring a long bone and then using a mathematic equation. Libal explains that since the body is proportionate, the length of one bone can be used to figure out the height of a person. After identifying biological profile, I checked for any marks on the bones like healed breaks, surgical marks, diseases, and abnormalities. These markings help match the bones with a missing person because markings are the same before and after death.

As a forensic anthropologist, I consulted with other people to find out who my dog found. After identifying the biological profile and unique markings, I called the FBI because they have one of the largest databases of missing people. I gave them all the information I got from examining the bones, and they searched through the database for a missing person that matched that profile. Their database did not have a match for the owner of the bones my dog found because the decedent was not reported as missing.

Since there was no match in the FBI database, I then consulted with a forensic artist. Forensic artists are important because they are able reconstruct the face of a victim. In "Giving Faces to the Lost," the author says "The artist (usually also a forensic anthropologist) uses the skull and knowledge of human anatomy to sculpt a face that will look enough like the victim to be recognizable to someone who knew her." This is significant because it explains that without a forensic artist using facial reconstruction it's hard to know what the person's face looks like. A face is needed to create a picture so others can identify the person.

After the bones were analyzed piece by piece and the facial reconstruction was done, the victim's family recognized the woman's picture. It turns out she was missing and her family didn't even know it. My work as a forensic anthropologist helped give a face to a once lost body.

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